

« BEFORE

President Nixon had been elected on his promise to end the war in Vietnam.

KEY POLICIES

Nixon's policy of **Vietnamization** gradually led to ARVN forces replacing US troops in all combat operations in Vietnam. Meanwhile, Nixon had instructed Henry Kissinger to conduct **secret talks** with the North Vietnamese in the hope of reaching a peace deal.



RALLYING THE ARVN

It was apparent to US strategists that Hanoi was planning something major for 1972, but they had no clear idea of what it might be. In September 1971, the Director of the CIA, Richard Helms, had briefed the National Security Council that something was afoot and expressed most concern about the DMZ and the Central Highlands. However, Washington's attitude remained upbeat and confident. In a presidential conversation with Henry Kissinger in November 1971, Nixon had expressed his desire for the US to take a hard "pop" against Hanoi after the 1972 presidential election, regardless of who became president. Nixon instructed Kissinger to reinforce the US fleet off Vietnamese shores.

Cause for alarm

At that point, the intelligence turned dark. North Vietnamese infiltration, which had been at a very low rate in summer and fall of 1971, increased exponentially over the winter, with 20,000 soldiers setting out along the Ho Chi Minh Trail in one week and 63,000 more following over a four-month span. Watchers at MACV noted the increase. Meanwhile, aerial reconnaissance detected a tank concentration bigger than anything they had seen previously, North Vietnamese jets at airfields in the southern panhandle of North Vietnam, and two dozen NVA surface-to-air missile battalions taking position in the DMZ-Trail area. Defense Intelligence Agency staff had also noticed a more aggressive tone in NVA and Viet Cong pronouncements.

Indications of a major offensive mounted. General Creighton Abrams and Joint Chiefs of Staff Chairman Admiral Thomas Moorer believed the attack would fall in the Central Highlands, but Washington focused on both the Highlands and the DMZ. On January 17, 1972, senior officials meeting in Washington tentatively predicted an attack in the DMZ in March and discussed how it could be met—ARVN capabilities and the scale of US support